

EVIDENTIARY COMPANION · MAY 2026

THE ACCESS GAP: THE \$200 TRAP

How Alberta deducts \$200 a month for a federal benefit many recipients cannot reach, and removed the one person who used to help them reach it

The earlier report in this series, *Penalized for Non-Ability*, documented how Alberta and federal disability systems are built so that the people they serve cannot navigate them. This companion documents what happens once that gap is not just a design flaw but an enforced penalty: a \$200 monthly deduction applied even to people who never receive the benefit it is named for, imposed at the same moment the government removed the caseworkers who used to help.

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The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

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THE CENTRAL FINDING

The earlier report in this series, *Penalized for Non-Ability*, documented how Alberta and federal disability systems are built so that the people they serve cannot navigate them. This companion documents what happens once that gap is not just a design flaw but an enforced penalty.

As of 2026, the Government of Alberta deducts \$200 a month from a disabled person's benefit for failing to secure the federal Canada Disability Benefit, including when the failure is caused by barriers the system itself built, and including when the person never receives the benefit at all. At the same time, the government removed the individual caseworkers who used to help people through those barriers and replaced them with a call centre.

The documented record establishes a closed loop: build a door most recipients cannot open, then fine them for not walking through it, then remove the person who used to hand them the key.

1. THE PENALTY: \$200 OFF, WHETHER OR NOT YOU EVER GET IT

The federal Canada Disability Benefit pays up to \$200 a month. Alberta is the only province that claws it back dollar-for-dollar, so an AISH or ADAP recipient sees no net gain from it. That much was already known.

What the 2026 enforcement documents add is this: the \$200 comes off whether or not the recipient actually receives the CDB.

- The Government of Alberta's own instructions state that if a decision on a recipient's CDB application has not been made by February 28, 2026, \$200 will be reduced from their benefits beginning with their April 2026 payments, before any benefit has been approved or paid.
- The government's April 2026 fact sheet for AISH recipients states that those who do not apply for the CDB, or who do not provide confirmation of their application status, including a denial, will have their monthly benefits reduced by \$200.
- Inclusion Alberta's guidance to recipients is blunt: apply or not, the \$200 may be deducted regardless.

This is a deemed-income penalty. The province docks \$200 for money the recipient may never see, on the basis that they should have it, without regard to whether the recipient was able to obtain it.

Sources: Government of Alberta, "Apply for federal disability supports" (alberta.ca); Government of Alberta, CDB/DTC Fact Sheet for AISH Recipients, April 2026; Inclusion Alberta, "Canada Disability Benefit in Alberta."

2. THE LOCKED DOOR: WHY MANY CANNOT GET THE CDB

To receive the Canada Disability Benefit, a person must first be approved for the federal Disability Tax Credit (DTC). The DTC is the door. For much of the AISH caseload, it is locked.

- The DTC application form (T2201) requires a section completed by a medical practitioner. The federal Disability Advisory Committee has identified the form's complexity as a primary barrier; roughly three in four online applicants abandon it before completion.
- More than 650,000 Albertans have no family doctor. A form that only a physician can sign is, for those people, a form they cannot get signed.
- Physicians may charge to complete the form. Documented fees run into the hundreds of dollars, as high as \$700, with no regulated maximum.
- The population being asked to clear this barrier is, by the program's own data, the least equipped to: of 79,290 AISH recipients, 28.3% have a cognitive disorder as their primary diagnosis and 30.2% have mental illness, and 83.6% report zero employment income.

The door requires a doctor most cannot find, a fee many cannot afford, and a form designed above the capacity of the people required to complete it. Then the \$200 penalty in Section 1 is applied for not getting through it.

Sources: Canada Revenue Agency, Form T2201; Government of Canada, Disability Advisory Committee reports; Inclusion Alberta (physician access and fees); Government of Alberta, AISH Caseload Open Data, September 2025.

3. THE "HELP" THAT IS A LOAN

The government's response to the physician-fee barrier is presented as assistance. Read in full, it is a loan.

The April 2026 fact sheet states that the AISH program will cover the cost of the DTC medical assessment for eligible clients, and then states that the client is required to repay the full amount. The program issues the fee as a supplemental benefit, the client pays the doctor, and the client then repays the program.

So the government's own answer to the barrier it built is to front the recipient a few hundred dollars to clear it, and then take that money back out of a benefit already documented as below the poverty line. The barrier is removed only on paper. The cost still lands on the recipient.

Source: Government of Alberta, CDB/DTC Fact Sheet for AISH Recipients, April 2026.

4. THE GUIDE REMOVED: FROM CASEWORKER TO CALL CENTRE

A person facing the trap above once had someone to call: an individual AISH caseworker who knew their file, their history, and their disability. In 2025, that role was removed for AISH clients and replaced with a centralized call centre.

The Voice of Albertans with Disabilities documented the result. Clients lose the worker who understood their history and circumstances. Every call means starting over with a new agent, repeating sensitive personal information, and navigating long waits, phone menus, and callback systems, barriers that fall hardest on exactly the cognitive and mental-health diagnoses that make up the majority of the caseload. When the change landed, the centre was so overwhelmed that callers were told to phone back the next day, day after day.

The timing is the point. At the precise moment the system ramped up a penalty for failing to navigate a complex federal-provincial compliance chain, it removed the one human being whose job was to help recipients navigate it.

Source: Voice of Albertans with Disabilities, reported September 2025 (caseworker removal and call-centre impact).

WHAT THE RECORD ESTABLISHES

This is the access gap not as theory but as enforcement. The government does not need to prove a recipient refused to comply. It deducts the \$200 regardless. The recipient must prove they cleared a barrier the government knows most of them cannot clear: find a doctor in a province where 650,000 Albertans have none, pay a fee they cannot afford, complete a form three-quarters of applicants abandon, and they must now do it without a caseworker.

The system frames the resulting loss as the recipient's non-compliance. The documented record frames it as predictable: a penalty engineered to land on a population the government's own data shows cannot meet the demand. They were told the barriers existed. They built the penalty anyway, and removed the help. Under Alberta's own Human Rights Act, and the accommodation duty it carries, that record raises a question the government has not answered: how is penalizing a disabled person for a barrier you built, and then billing them for the help, an accommodation of disability rather than a denial of it?

The "we did not know people could not get through" defence does not survive an inbox.

IF THIS IS HAPPENING TO YOU

- You can be docked \$200 even while your CDB application is still in progress, and even if it is denied. Knowing that is not the same as agreeing it is fair.
- Apply for the DTC and CDB if you are able, and tell your AISH or Alberta Supports contact in writing every time you take a step, with dates. A written record of your efforts is your protection.
- If a physician's fee is the barrier, ask the AISH program in writing to cover the DTC medical assessment, and know going in that they will ask you to repay it, so get that arrangement in writing too.
- If the call centre cannot help you, you can escalate: ask for a supervisor, and you can bring concerns to the Alberta Ombudsman.
- Keep every letter, every reference number, every date. You are not building a complaint. You are building a record.